

SESSION 06

Spread Composition and Grid Breaks

Five decisions govern every spread, and when it's earned, breaking the grid is one of them.

Portfolio as Narrative · Building the Grid, Part II

Design for Understanding

Designing for the Reader, Not for Yourself

- A strong portfolio isn't only about what you think matters.
- **It's about** how clearly your story is understood by someone else.
- **Clarity doesn't come from intention alone**, it comes from design.
- To communicate effectively, you need to understand how people see, read, and process visual information.

“Design is not just what it looks like and feels like. Design is how it works.”

— Steve Jobs

WHAT THE READER SEES FIRST

- Dominant image
- Supporting images
- Captions & specs

Primary → secondary → tertiary: the order a reviewer's eye actually follows, whether or not you designed for it.

Learning Objectives

By the end of tonight, you will be able to:



1

Apply principles from visual perception and cognitive science to make more intentional layout decisions.



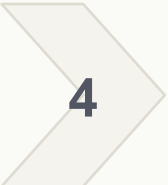
2

Use hierarchy, grouping, and flow to organize the two spreads you build out tonight.



3

Diagnose layout issues in your own and your classmates' spreads using a structured set of questions.



4

Revise in real time to improve clarity, pacing, and how quickly a reviewer understands what they're looking at.

Eight Reader-Centered Layout Principles

Eight memory tags. Each one compresses a real study in cognitive or perceptual psychology.

Principle	Memory Tag	Helps You...
1. Cognitive Load Theory	Declutter	Focus each spread by reducing distractions
2. Dual Coding Theory	Pair It	Reinforce visuals with concise supporting text
3. Spatial Contiguity	Keep It Together	Place related images and text near each other
4. Gestalt Grouping	Pattern It	Use grouping, alignment, and similarity
5. Visual Hierarchy	Lead the Eye	Guide attention using scale and placement
6. Scanning Patterns	Flow It	Align layout to natural eye movement
7. Information Scent	Signal the Path	Use labels and structure to aid navigation
8. Whitespace	Let It Breathe	Use space to emphasize and clarify

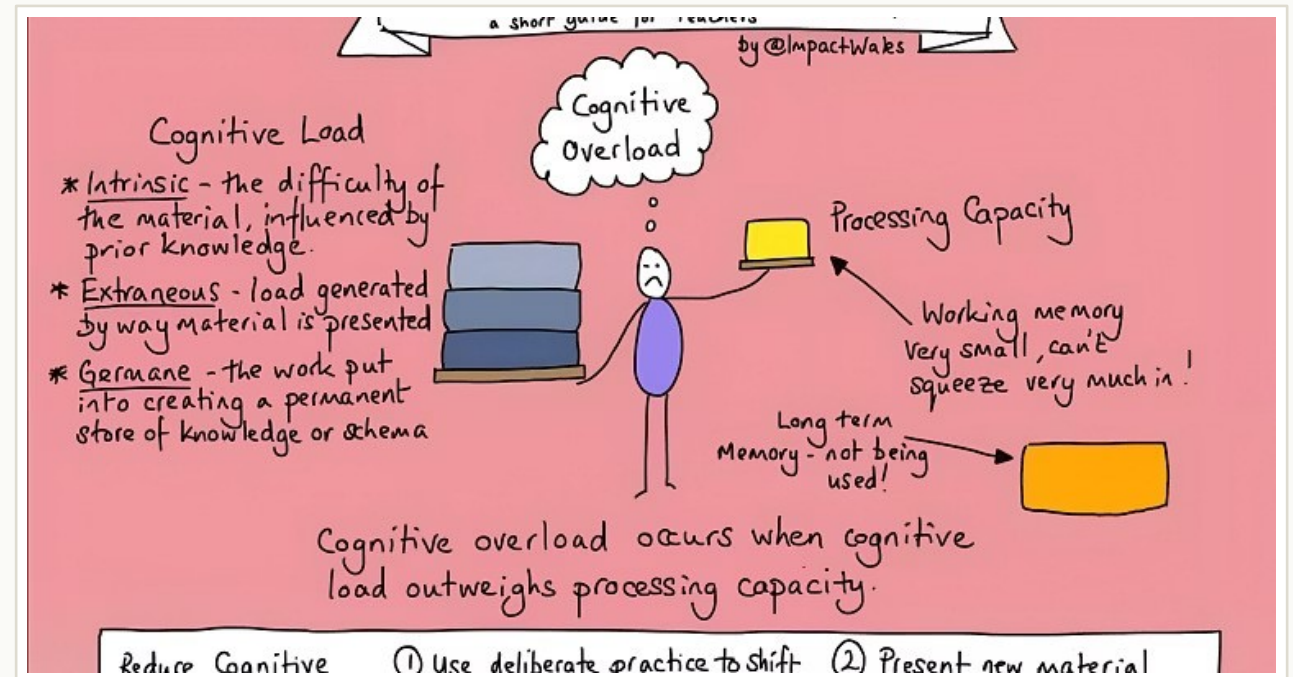
Principle 1 — Cognitive Load Theory (“Declutter”)

Theory Summary

Too much information overwhelms the viewer's working memory (Sweller, 1988). Working memory holds roughly four items at a time, for seconds, not minutes. When a spread overloads it, viewers miss key points and fail to retain the content.

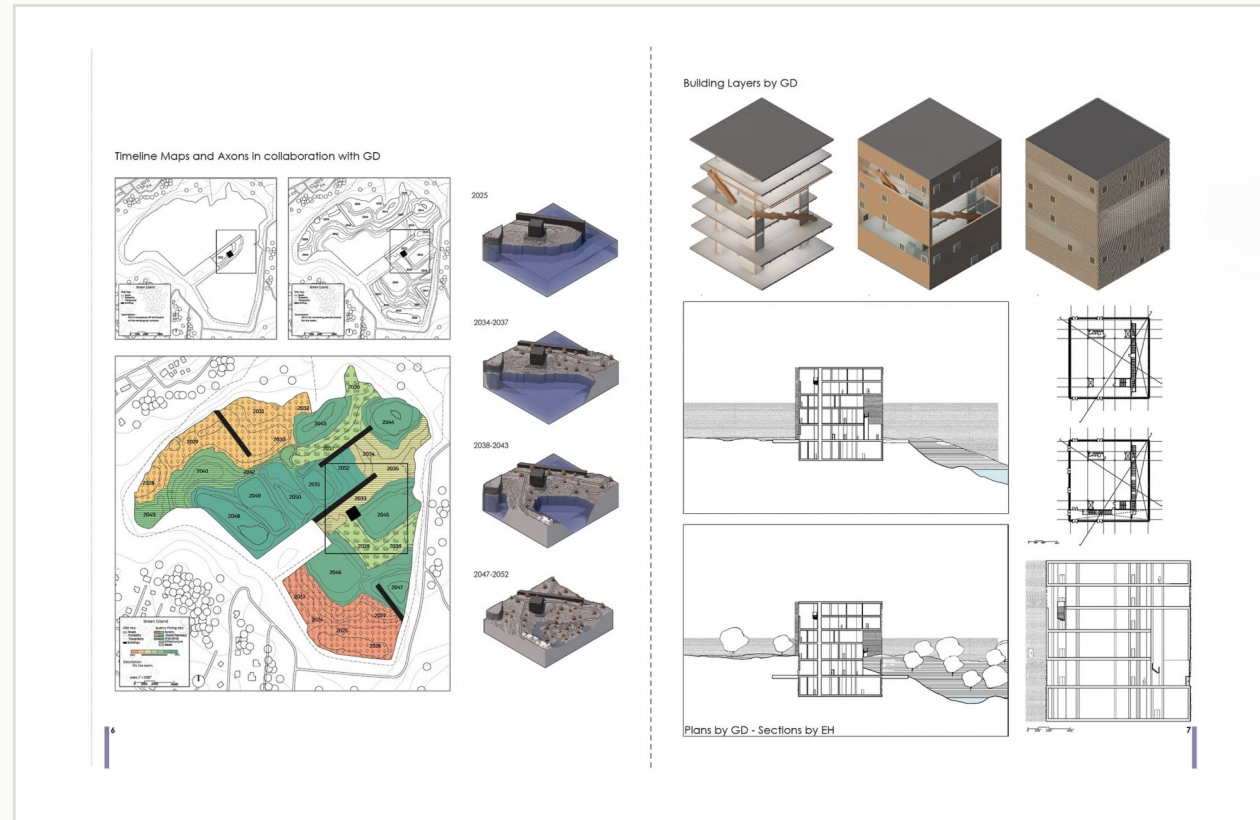
Application

- Focus on one main idea per spread
- Remove visual noise and irrelevant text
- Eliminate decorative elements that don't contribute
- Be ruthless about editing down content



[Sweller, J. \(1988\). Cognitive load during problem solving. Cognitive Science, 12\(2\), 257–285.](#)

Six Images, One Working Memory



Timeline maps and axons, a full site plan, an exploded building diagram, floor plans: every one of them is asking for the same four-item memory budget at once.

One Idea, Everything Else in Support



One rendering carries the spread. The plan and section support it at clearly smaller scale. Nothing here is competing for the same attention.

Principle 2 — Dual Coding Theory (“Pair It”)

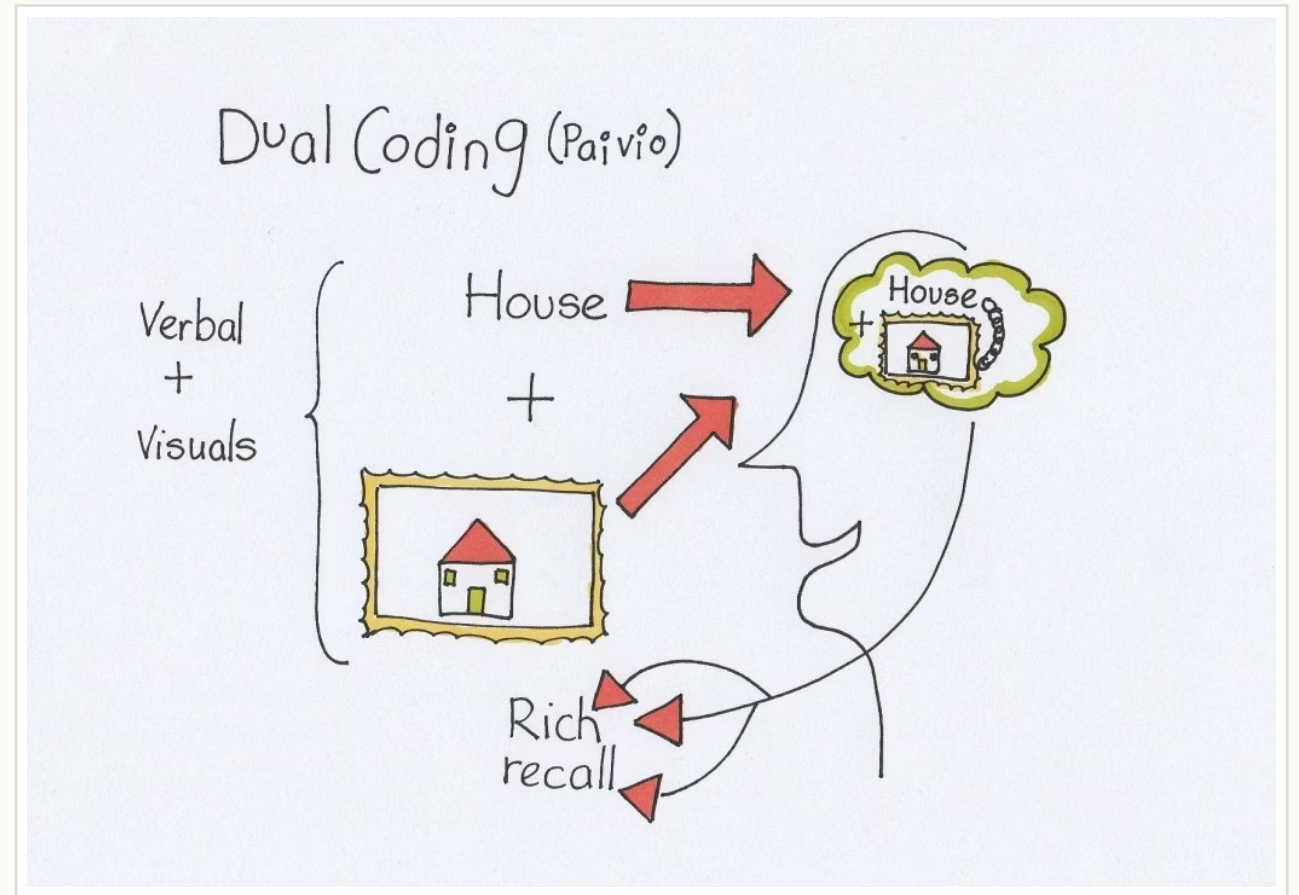
Theory Summary

We process and retain information better when it's presented through both visual and verbal channels (Paivio, 1971). The brain has separate systems for visual and verbal information. Used together, they reinforce each other.

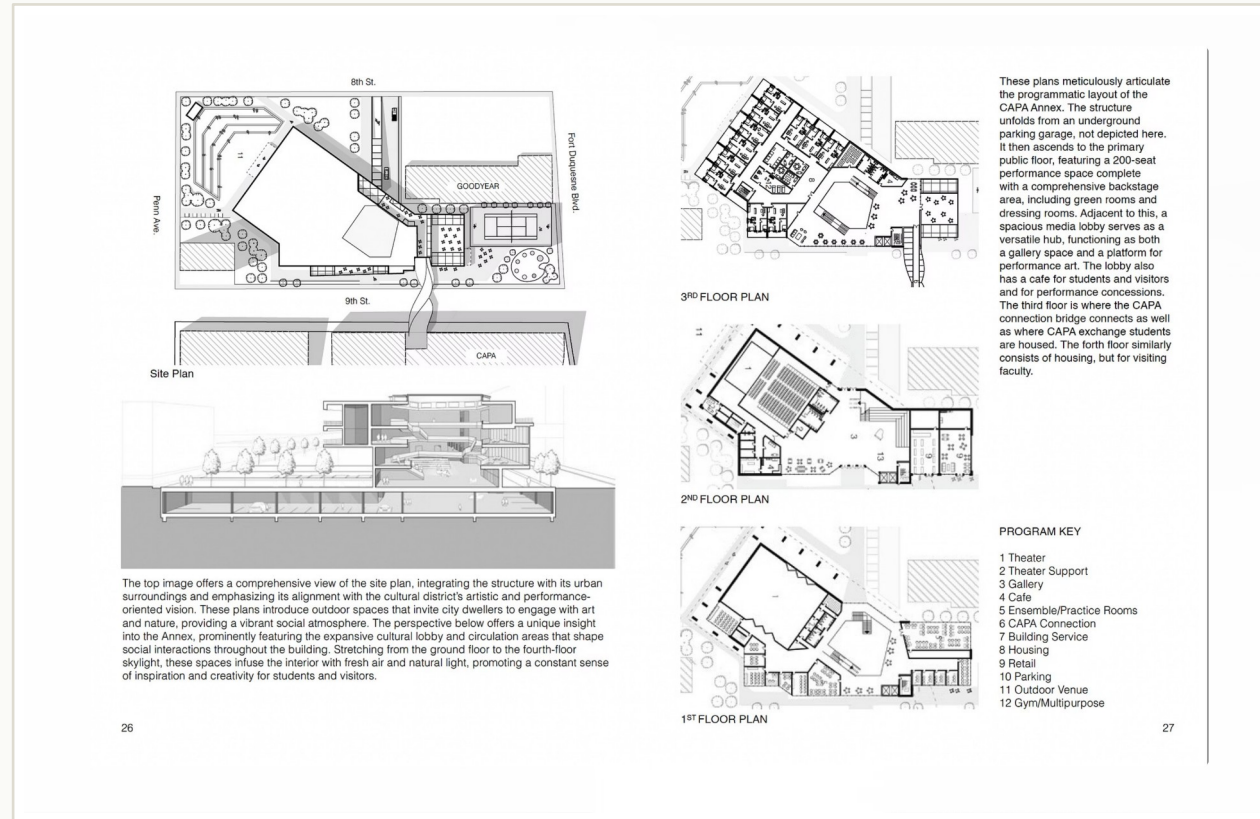
Application

- Combine visuals and text to improve memory
- Use concise captions that reinforce, not repeat
- Break up dense text with supporting imagery
- Label diagrams clearly but minimally

[Paivio, A. \(1971\). *Imagery and Verbal Processes*. Holt, Rinehart and Winston.](#)



A Caption Block, Not a Pairing



A full paragraph sits beside the plans, but it doesn't point at anything specific in them. Reading the text and reading the drawings are two separate tasks.

Caption and Image, Working Together



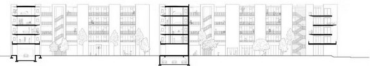
rendering of the workday plaza, a playground provides space for children to play and seating for families to gather.

8 | Nick McInerney



ground floor plan

ground floor contains programs such as pharmacy, market, workshops, communal living room, maker space, kindergarten, communal workshop room, cafe, swimming pool, communal garden, basketball court, and playground.



cross-section building section (cutting through open plaza and playground plaza.)

Generative Housing | 9

Each caption makes a claim the image alone can't: who the plaza serves, what the ground floor holds. Neither channel just repeats the other.

Principle 3 — Spatial Contiguity (“Keep It Together”)

Theory Summary

Learning improves when related words and images are presented near each other rather than separated (Mayer, 2001). The brain expends less cognitive effort when it doesn't have to search for and connect related elements.

Application

- Place labels, diagrams, and captions close to what they describe
- Use directional cues like leader lines only when necessary
- Avoid separating explanatory text from its visual
- Create clear visual connections between related items

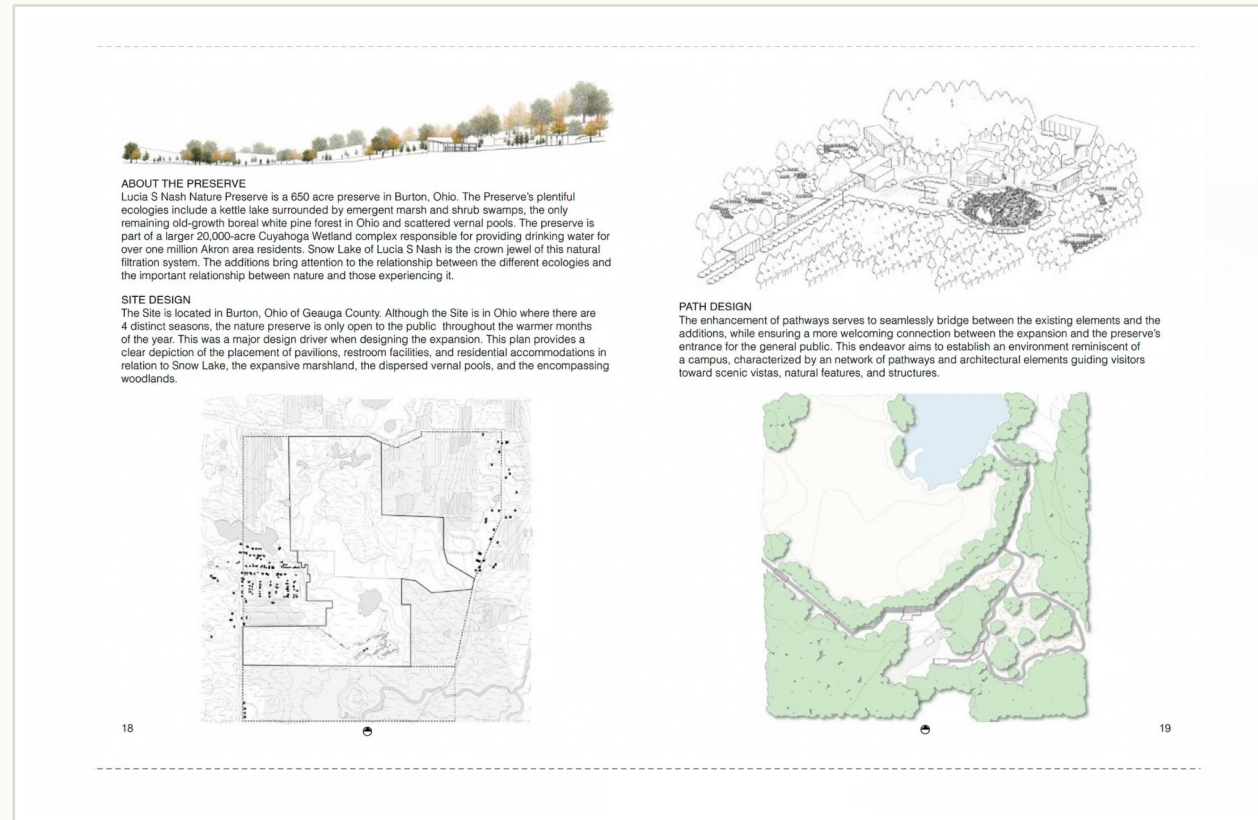
Spatial Contiguity



Place words & pictures near each other on the page or screen

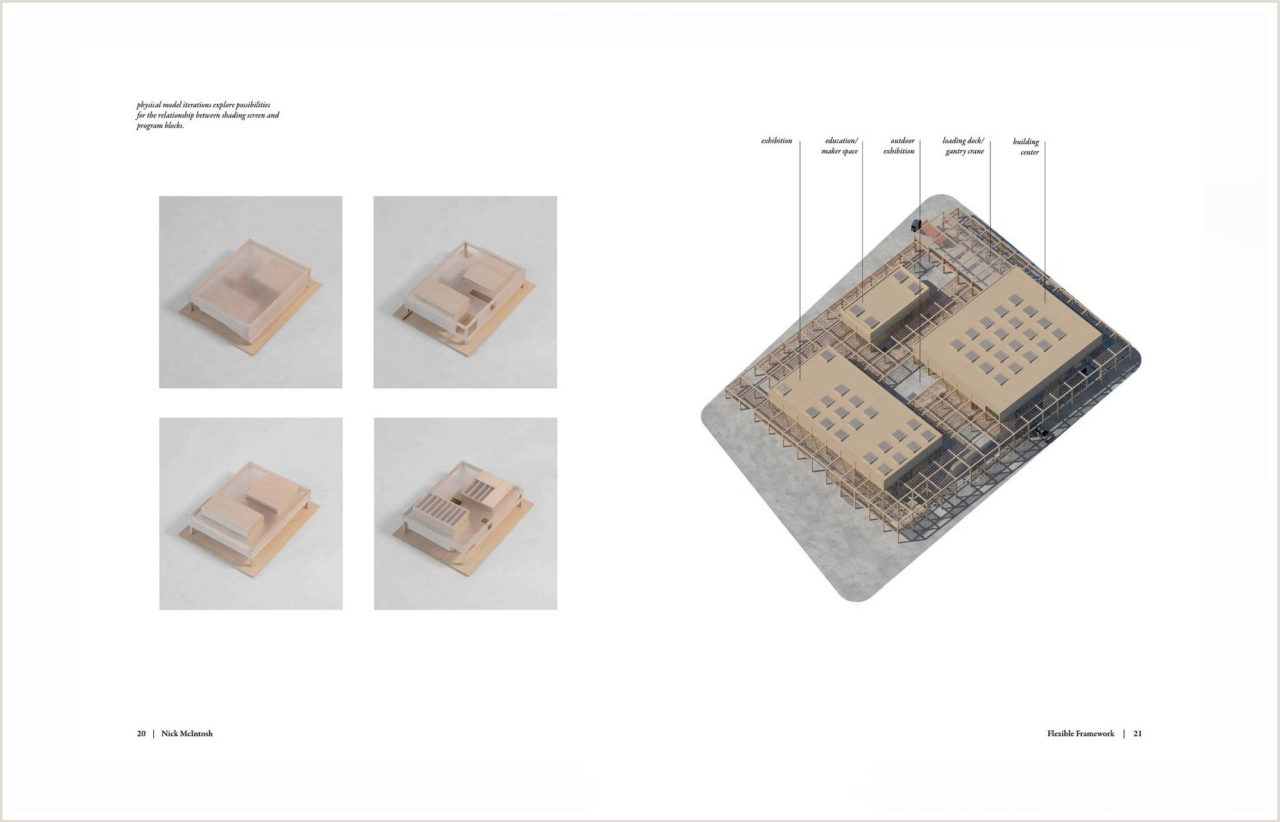
[Mayer, R. E. \(2001\). *Multimedia Learning*. Cambridge University Press.](#)

The Text Explains, Three Inches Away



Site description paragraphs sit above the maps they describe, not beside them. Matching a sentence to its map is left entirely to the reader.

Labels Land on What They Name



Program labels sit directly against the roof plan they identify, one leader line, zero search-and-match required.

Principle 4 — Gestalt Grouping (“Pattern It”)

Theory Summary

Viewers naturally perceive and organize visual elements based on patterns of proximity, similarity, continuity, and closure (Koffka, 1935). The brain automatically groups related elements and seeks order in visual information.

Application

- **Proximity:** objects near each other appear related
- **Similarity:** similar items are perceived as a group
- **Continuity:** elements aligned in a pattern appear connected
- **Closure:** we mentally complete incomplete shapes

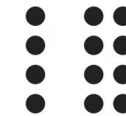
[Koffka, K. \(1935\). *Principles of Gestalt Psychology*. Harcourt, Brace and Company.](#)

Gestalt Principles



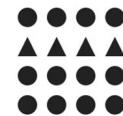
Good Figure

Objects grouped together tend to be perceived as a single figure. Tendency to simplify.



Proximity

Objects tend to be grouped together if they are close to each other.



Similarity

Objects tend to be grouped together if they are similar.



Continuation

When there is an intersection between two or more objects, people tend to perceive each object as a single uninterrupted object.



Closure

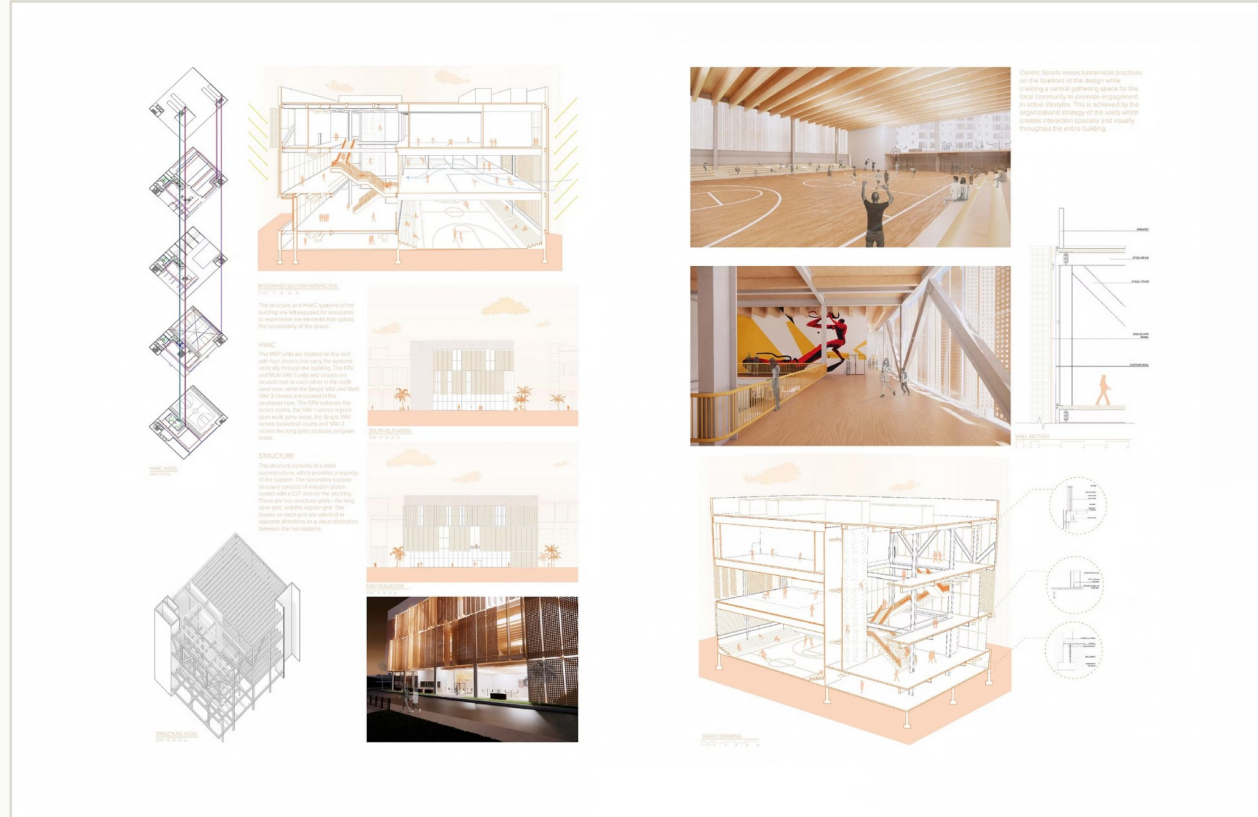
Visual connection or continuity between sets of elements which do not actually touch each other in a composition.



Symmetry

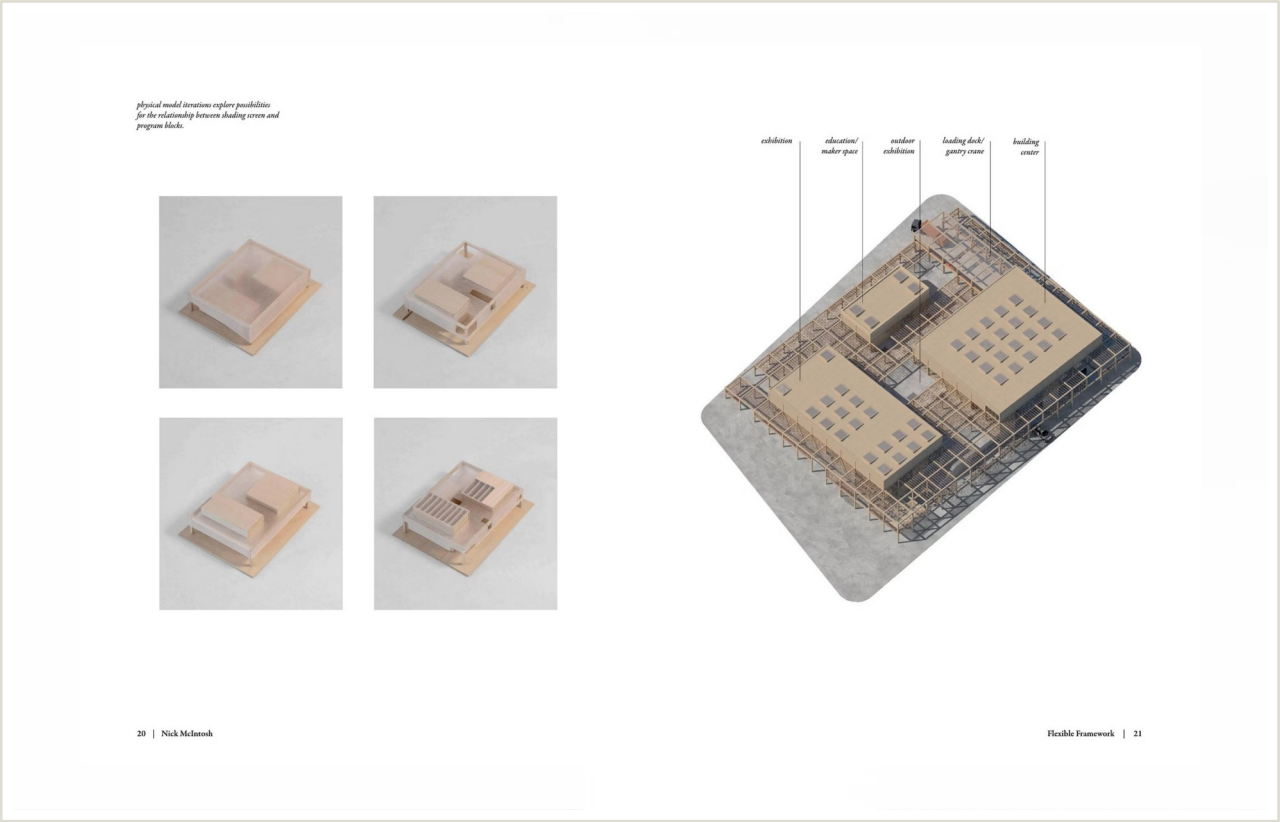
The object tend to be perceived as symmetrical shapes that form around their center.

Six Drawings, No Grouping Logic



An axon, two elevations, a photo, a section perspective, an exploded diagram: all the same size and weight, none of them reading as belonging together or apart.

Four Studies, Read as One Family



Four model photographs, same size, same proximity, same framing: proximity and similarity group them as one set of iterations without a single label saying so.

Principle 5 — Visual Hierarchy (“Lead the Eye”)

Theory Summary

The brain naturally processes visual information in order of prominence (Lupton, 2004). Deliberate differences in size, weight, and position guide the viewer through your content, primary elements first, tertiary details last.

Application

- **Primary:** headers and key images command attention first
- **Secondary:** supporting visuals and subheadings provide context
- **Tertiary:** captions and specifications add depth
- Position primary elements at entry points, top or left

[Lupton, E. \(2004\). *Thinking with Type*. Princeton Architectural Press.](#)



Scale

Larger objects attract more attention. The biggest element should be the most important one.



Color

Bold, saturated color pulls the eye before anything else is processed.



Contrast

A dramatic shift in color or weight signals that something is different here.



Alignment

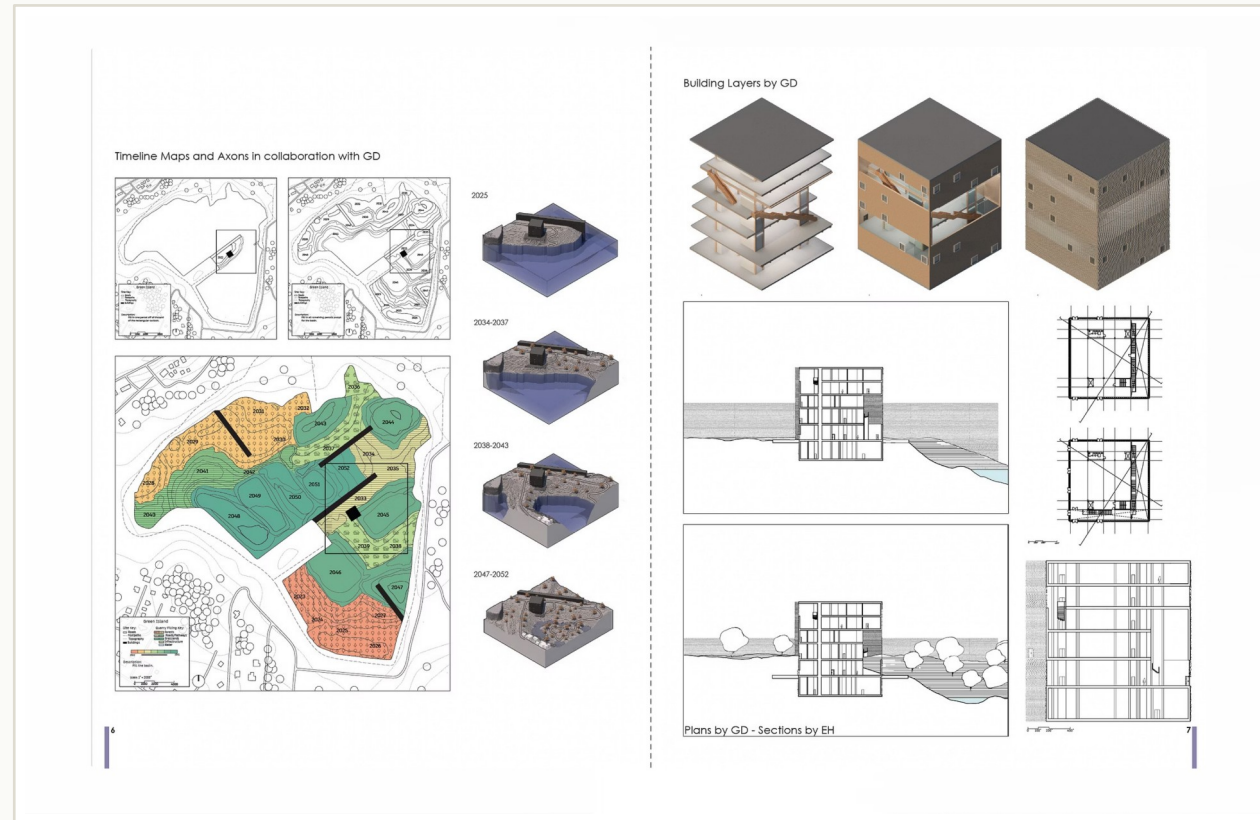
Order between elements is created by alignment, guiding the eye along a line.



Proximity

Objects close together read as one group before the content is even read.

Every Element Fighting for First Place



Nothing here is sized or positioned to go first. The eye has no instructions, so it goes nowhere in particular.

One Element Wins, on Purpose



The plaza rendering is large, isolated, and placed first. The plan and section are smaller and clearly secondary. The hierarchy is legible before a single word is read.

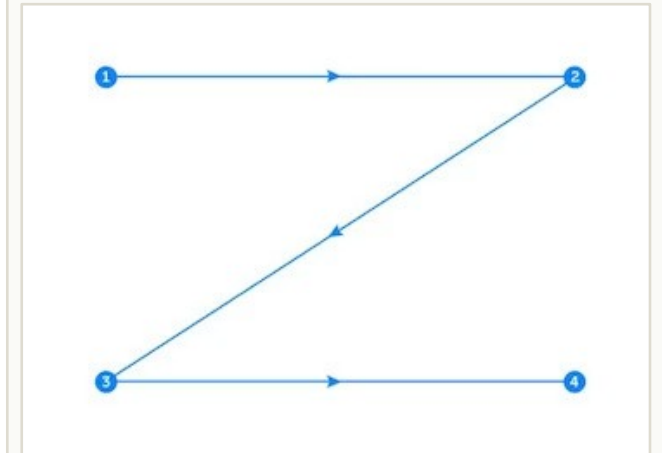
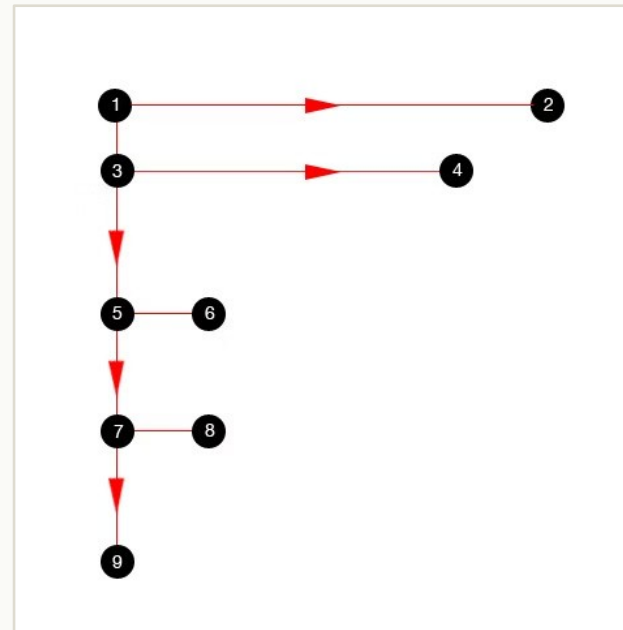
Principle 6 — Scanning Patterns (“Flow It”)

Theory Summary

Viewers scan text-heavy pages in an F-shape: across the top, down slightly, across again, then down the left side (Nielsen, 2006). More visual, image-dominant spreads tend toward a Z-path instead. Align your most important content along these natural paths.

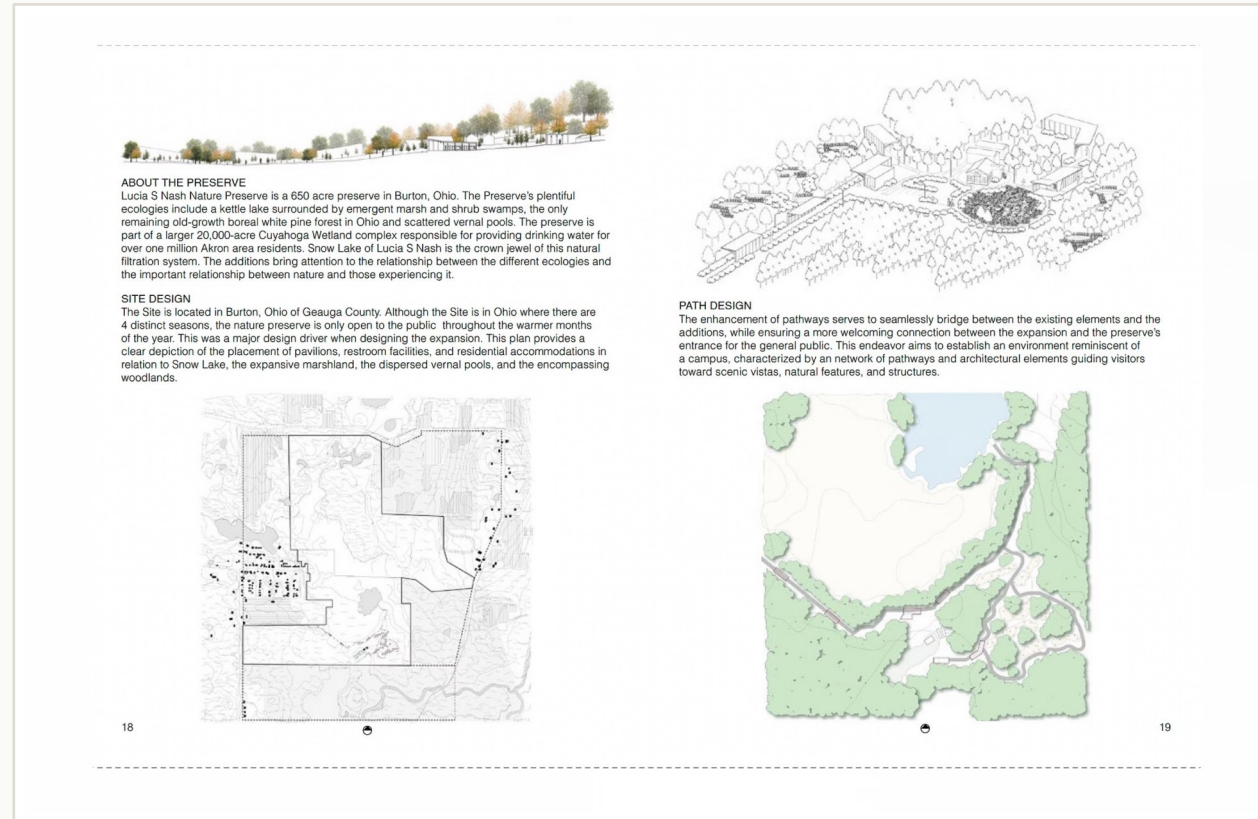
Application

- Position titles, key images, and conclusions at the path's terminal points
- A text-heavy spread: expect an F-path
- A visually dominant spread: expect a Z-path
- Test it: trace where your eye actually lands first



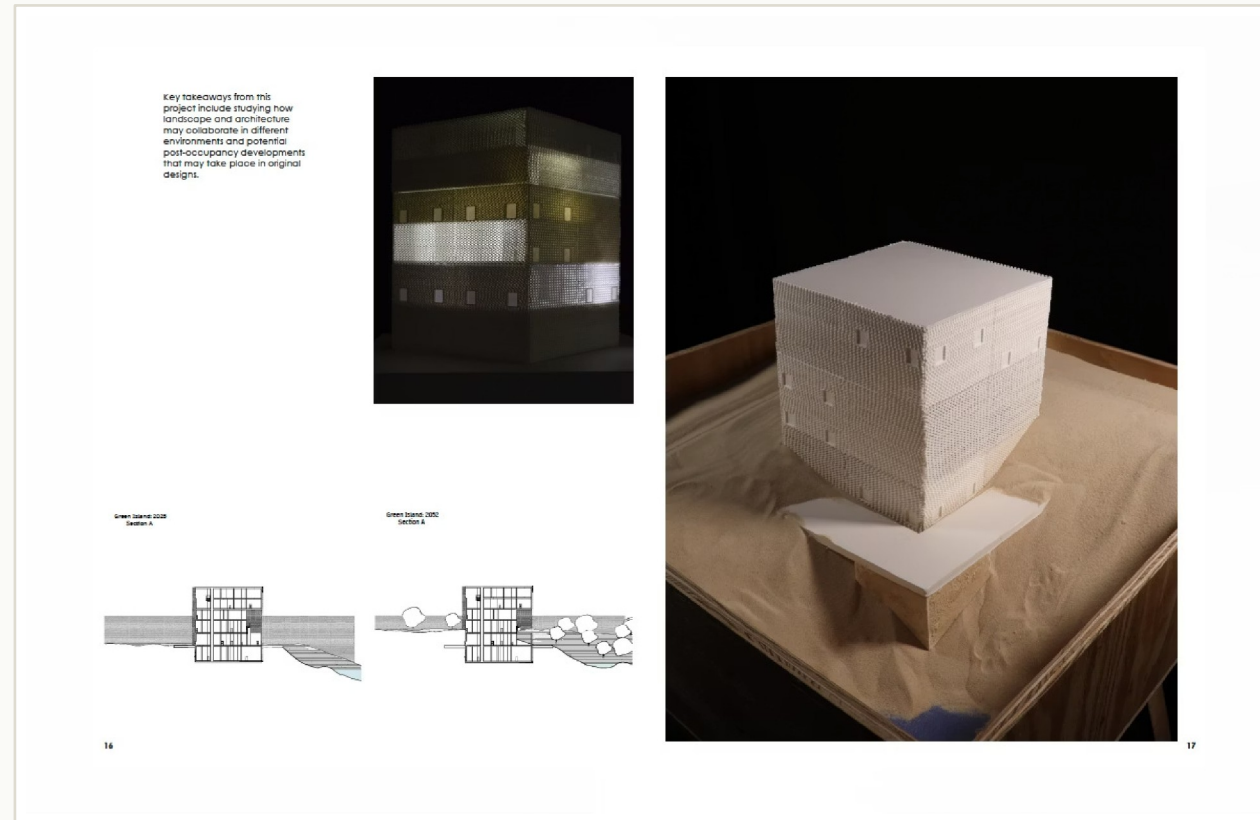
[Nielsen, J. \(2006\). F-Shaped Pattern for Reading Web Content. Nielsen Norman Group.](#)

No Path, Just Paragraphs



Dense text blocks give the eye nowhere predictable to land. A reviewer scanning this page is searching, not reading.

One Path, Impossible to Miss



A single full-bleed image claims the entire right page. There's exactly one place for the eye to go first, and it's the right one.

Principle 7 — Information Scent (“Signal the Path”)

Theory Summary

Viewers use cues in the environment to predict where to find information and how to navigate content (Pirolli & Card, 1999). Strong “information scent” helps viewers understand content organization and follow your intended narrative.

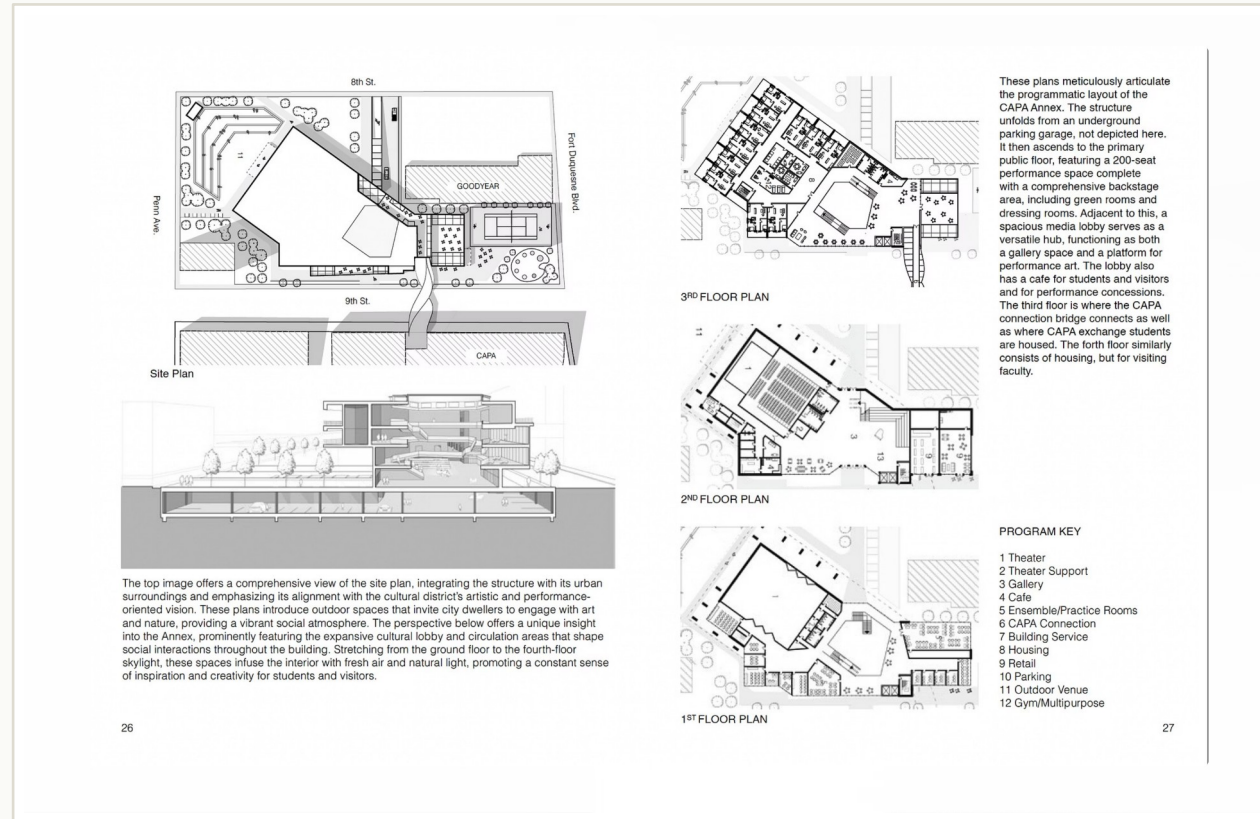
Application

- Use consistent, descriptive labels and section headers
- Structure your project as: Concept → Process → Design Development → Result
- Use section markers, color tabs, or page numbers to show progression
- Maintain typographic and layout consistency across projects



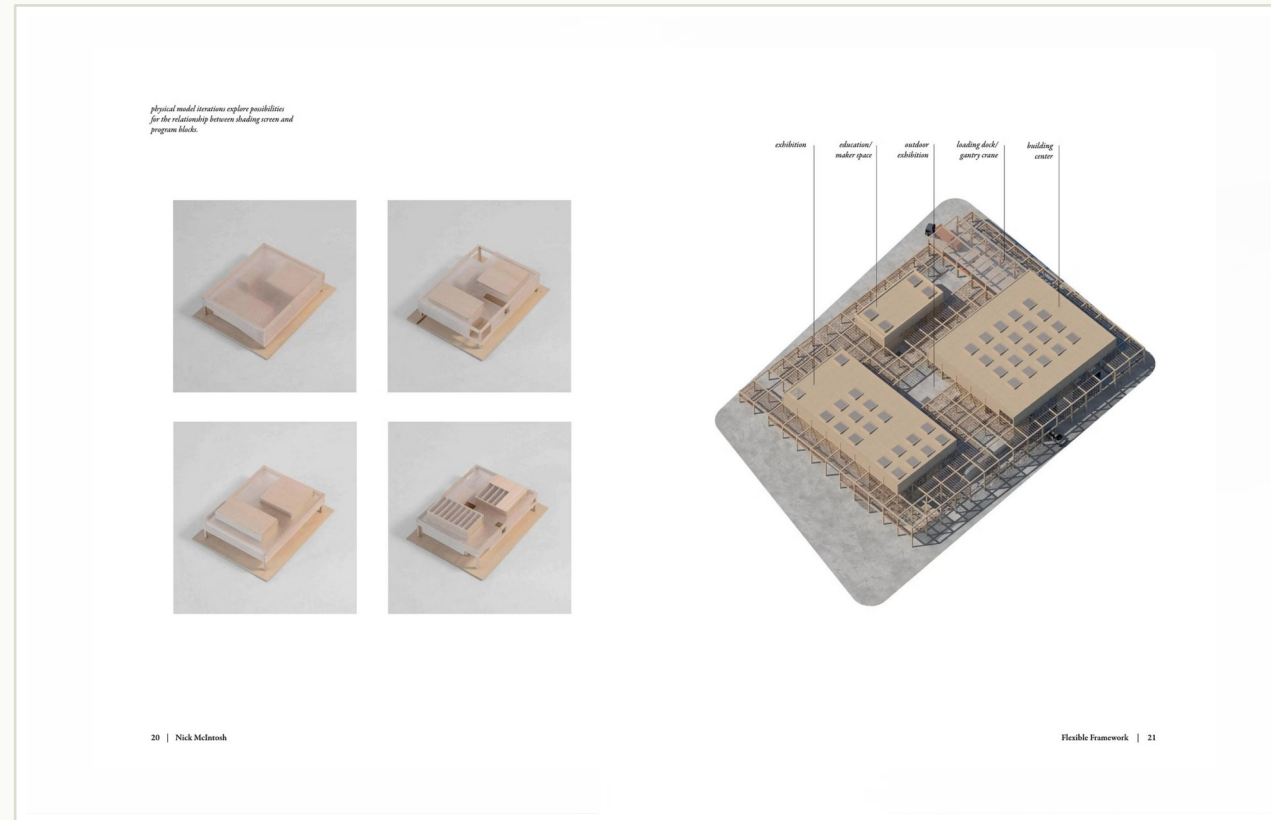
[Pirolli, P., & Card, S. \(1999\). Information foraging. *Psychological Review*, 106\(4\), 643–675.](#)

A Program Key Instead of a Reading Path



A twelve-item numbered key tells you what's in the building. It doesn't tell you what to look at first, or what story the spread is telling.

Consistent Labels, Predictable Navigation



The same caption convention, italic, lowercase, positioned the same way, runs across every spread in this portfolio. A reviewer learns the pattern once and can predict it everywhere after.

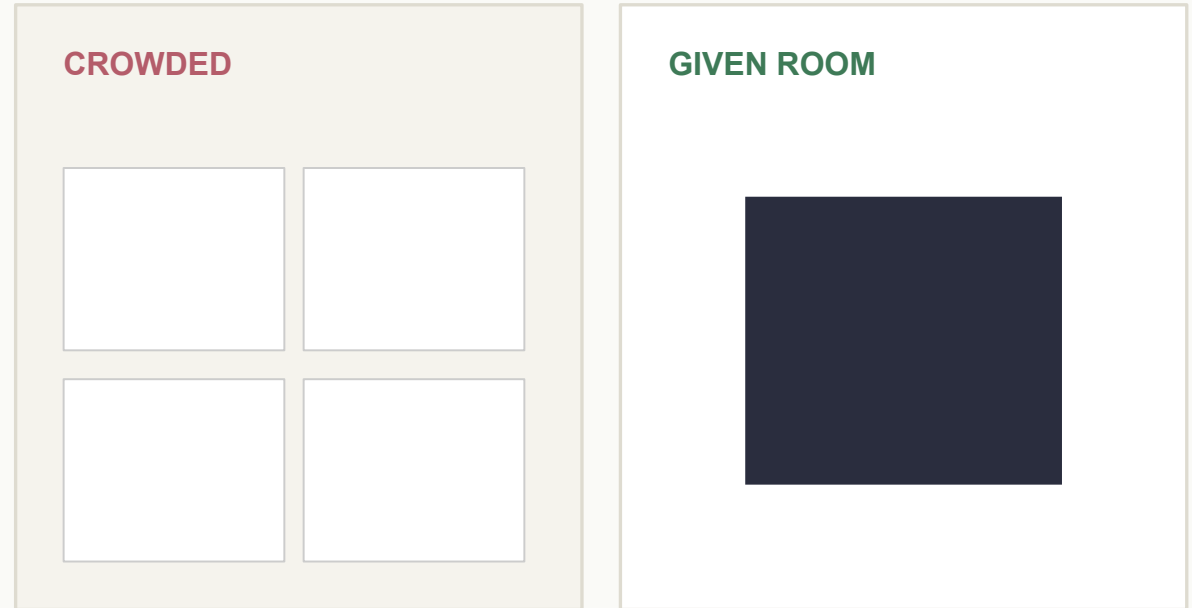
Principle 8 — Whitespace (“Let It Breathe”)

Theory Summary

Space is not empty. It's an active design element that supports comprehension and emphasis (Tufte, 1990). The brain needs visual pauses to process information. Whitespace reduces cognitive load and increases perceived value.

Application

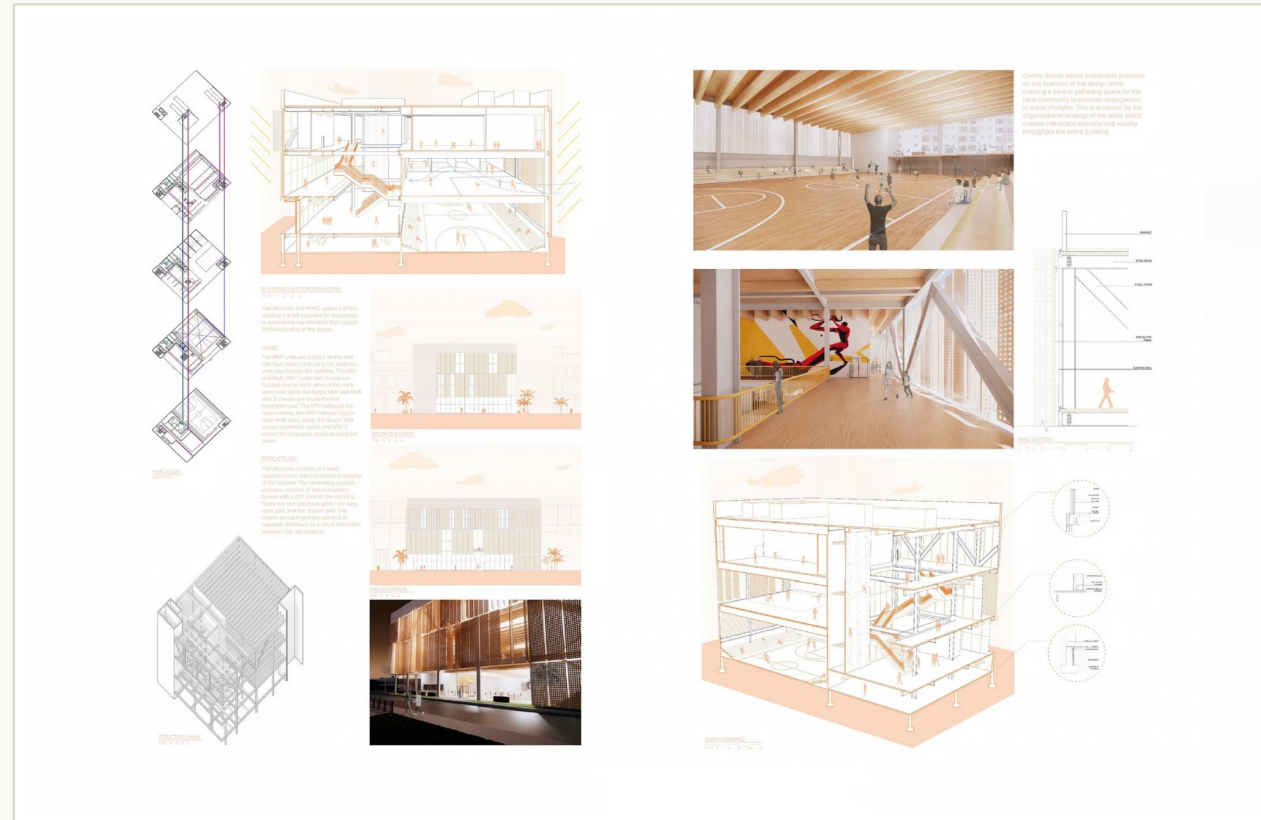
- Use consistent margins around page edges
- Create breathing room between elements
- Allow important elements more surrounding space
- Develop rhythm through alternating dense and open spreads



The identical drawing, crowded against three neighbors on the left, given generous margins on the right. Nothing about the drawing changed. Its perceived importance did (Tufte, 1990).

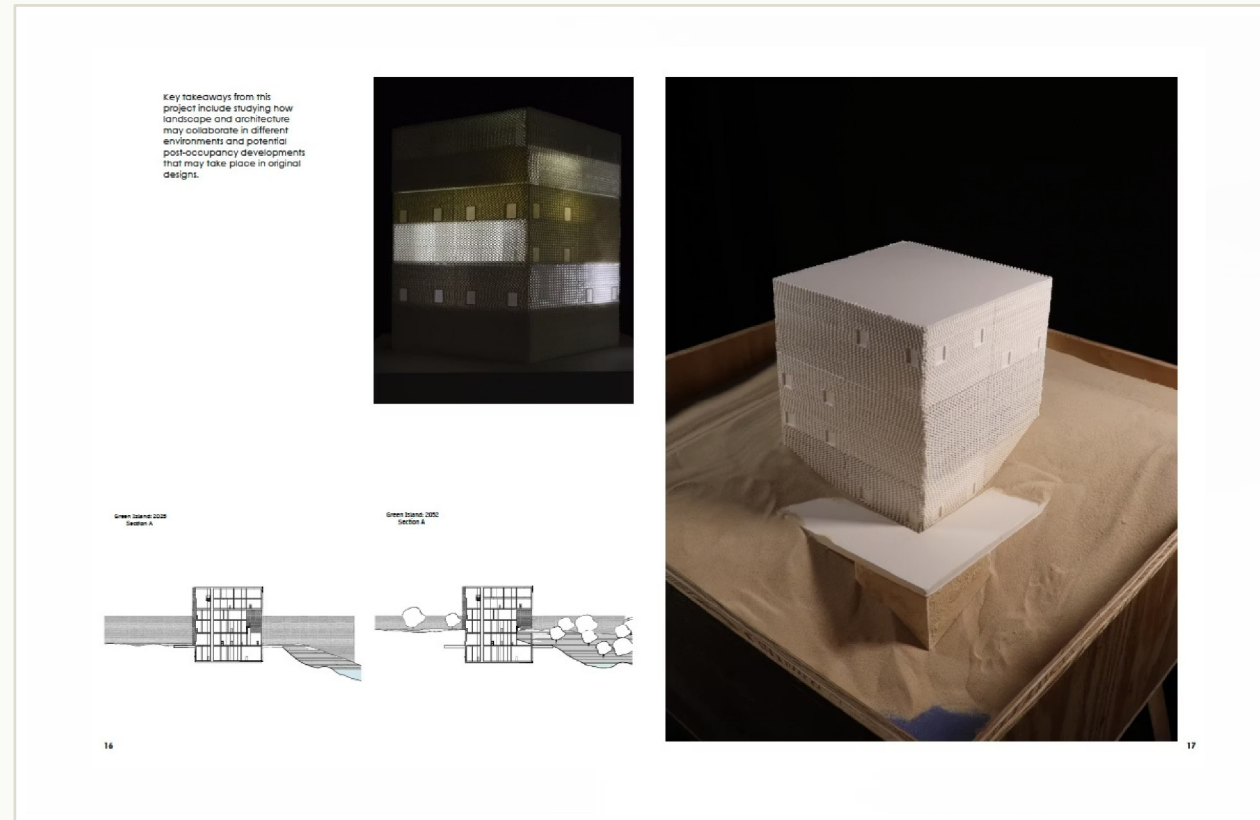
[Tufte, E. R. \(1990\). *Envisioning Information*. Graphics Press.](#)

No Room Left to Breathe



Six drawing types packed edge to edge, with almost no margin between any of them. Nothing on this page gets to feel important, because nothing gets space to itself.

Space as the Argument



The hero image is given the entire page, alone. The emptiness around the smaller details isn't unfinished. It's what tells you those details are secondary.

From Principles to Decisions

Every reader-centered principle tonight has a direct counterpart in the five spread decisions.

TONIGHT'S PRINCIPLE		THE SPREAD DECISION IT DRIVES
Visual Hierarchy	→	Dominance
Scanning Patterns	→	Left-Right Relationship
Visual Hierarchy (levels)	→	Image Scaling
Whitespace	→	Whitespace
Spatial Contiguity + Gestalt Grouping	→	Composite Logic

The five decisions are not a separate system. They're what the eight principles look like once you're actually placing content on a page.

Grid Breaks, Earned

The Full-Bleed Image

No margins, no columns, no modules. Works as punctuation: a section divider, a project opener, a closing image. Earn it first, don't open with it.

The Oversized Element

Crosses column or module boundaries to signal hierarchy. Still aligns to column edges, it simply claims more modules than its neighbors.

The Deliberate Void

A title page with a name, a one-line statement, and one image, using the grid's full capacity by choosing to fill only a fraction of it.

The one test: can a reviewer see that the break is intentional? If it looks like an accident, it undermines the argument. If nothing on your spread earns a break tonight, leave the grid intact.

ACTIVITY

Tonight's Activity

Open your real project file from Session 05, the one with your grid, baseline, and paragraph styles already built, and start placing real content into it.

- Two spreads, minimum, with real drawings and renderings, not placeholder boxes
- Name the dominant element on each spread before placing anything else
- Captions placed by spatial contiguity, directly against what they describe
- Consistent labels: a section marker, project title, or page number on each
- A grid break only if a spread has actually earned one

TIMING

30 minutes

Then 20 minutes of small-group peer review using tonight's evaluation questions.

DUE TONIGHT

Your real project file (.indd), two grid-aligned spreads built out with real content, submitted before you leave.

Design for the Reader, Not the Instinct

Eight principles, five decisions, one test for every grid break. None of it replaces a good project. All of it decides whether a reviewer actually sees one.

OPTIONAL READING

“How the Eye Reads a Spread”, the research behind tonight's eight principles.

NEXT SESSION

Session 07: Typography as Architectural Voice